

Binary Search

Binary search

steps: 0

37



Sequential search

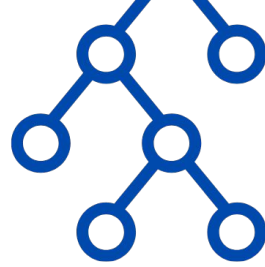
steps: 0

37



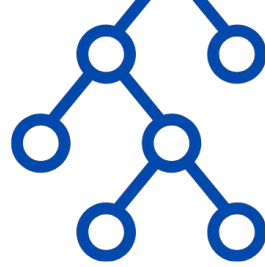
Learning Objective

1. Understanding the Binary Search Algorithm
2. Understanding why the Algorithm is Efficient
3. Understanding the Algorithm's Requirements
4. Exploring Applications and Use Cases



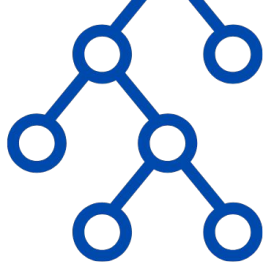
Lecture Flow

1. Prerequisites
2. Introduction
3. Naive Approach
4. Binary Search
5. Variants
6. Common Pitfalls
7. Quote of the day



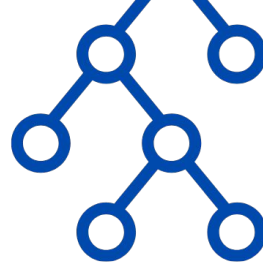
Pre-requisites

1. Array
2. Sorting
3. Loops and conditional statements

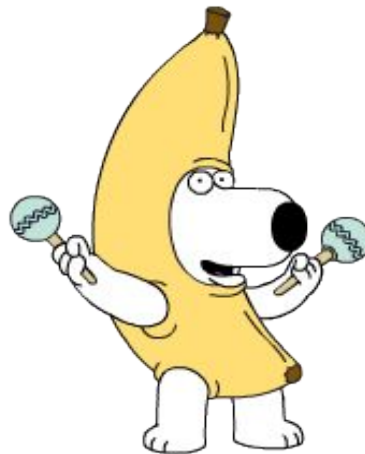


Introduction

Let's play a game.



Guess the Number



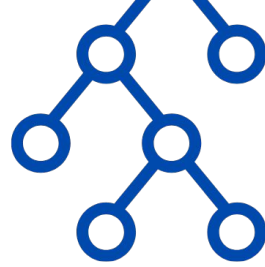
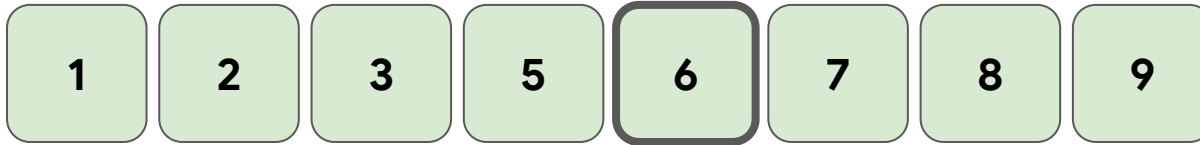
Introduction

- Binary Search is one of the most fundamental and useful algorithms in Computer Science.
- It describes the [process of searching for a specific value](#) in an ordered collection.



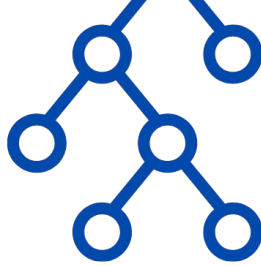
Naive Approach

Given a sorted list of numbers search for 6

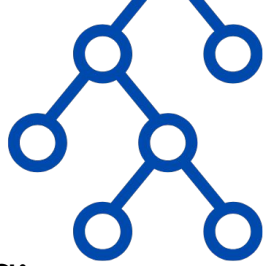


Naive Approach

You iterate until we find the number. It takes 5 steps.



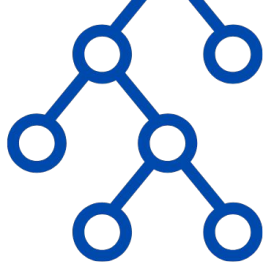
Naive Approach - Time Complexity



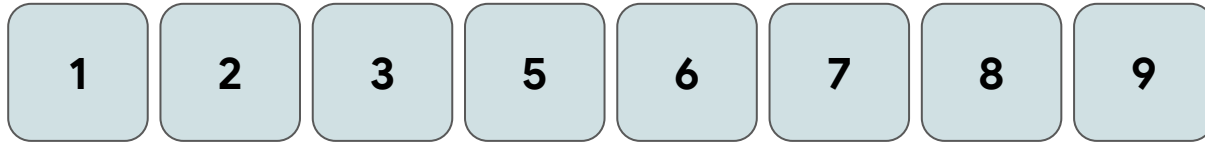
Worst case scenario: when the element to be searched is at the end. Eg:
when target is 9. $O(n)$



Binary Search



We know the numbers are sorted. Is there a room for optimization?



Binary Search

Let's call the region of the list we are looking for the number in **the search space**. We will start with the whole list as the search space.



Binary Search

Let's pick a number around the middle. If the picked number is smaller than the target number, we make the search space after the picked number.

Otherwise, we make the search space until this number.



Binary Search

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Binary Search

Let's pick a number around the middle. If the picked number is smaller than the target number, we make the search space after the picked number.

Otherwise, we make the search space until this number : 3 steps



Practice

Binary Search

Binary Search - Time Complexity

What is the number of steps needed to **make the search space size exactly 1**?
On each iteration we are halving the it.



$$\underbrace{1 * 2 * 2 * \dots * 2}_{\text{Number of steps Times}} = \text{problem size}$$

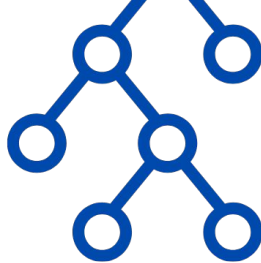


$$2^{(\text{number of steps})} = \text{problem size}$$



$$\text{Number of steps} = \log_2(\text{problem size})$$

Note



```
mid = (high + low) // 2
```

Unlike in python, this could result in an overflow, in other languages. So use this instead.

```
mid = low + (high - low) // 2
```



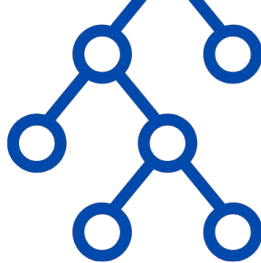
A more general way of thinking

Not all binary search problems are about finding the right position in a sorted list.

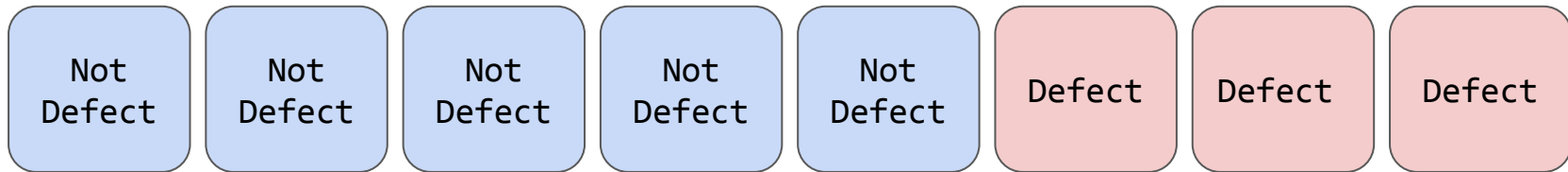
[Problem Link](#)



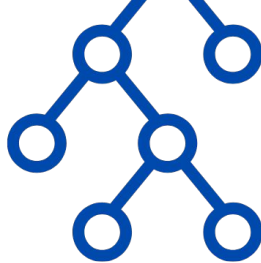
A more general way of thinking



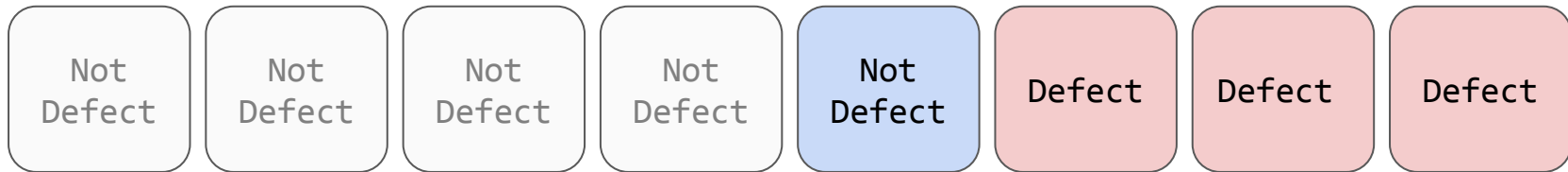
In this problem we are looking for the first time we get a defect.



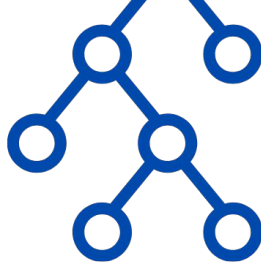
A more general way of thinking



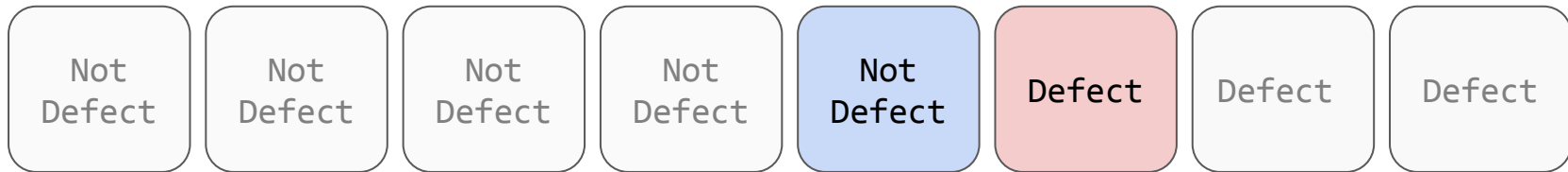
Cut the search space by half every time



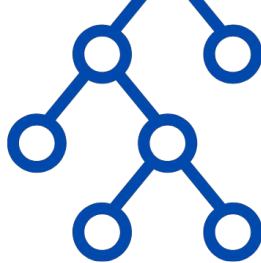
A more general way of thinking



Cut the search space by half every time



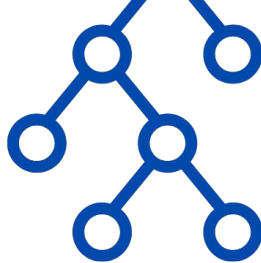
A more general way of thinking



Cut the search space by half every time



A more general template



```
def binarySearch(low=1, high=1, key = lambda x: True):  
  
    while low <= high:  
        mid = low + (high - low)//2  
        if key(mid):  
            high = mid - 1  
        else:  
            low = mid + 1  
    return low
```



Variants

Variant 1 - Over an input space

This is the variant we have seen, where we search for a particular value in the given input

In other words, **the search space is given explicitly** by the problem.



Variant 1 - Over an input space

Practice

[Problem Link](#)

Variant 2 - Over an output space

The search is applied **over the a possible output range**. For every choice there is usually a linear check to validate the choice

This is trickier than the first variant.



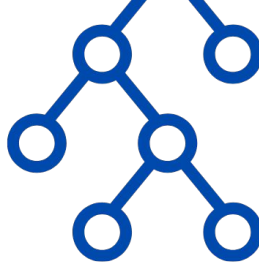
Variant 2 - Over an output space

Practice

[Problem Link](#)

Common Pitfalls

Common Pitfalls



- Not checking the right condition for loop termination;
 $\text{low} < \text{high}$ vs $\text{low} \leq \text{high}$ vs $\text{low} + 1 < \text{high}$
- Off-by-one on the search space
- Unreachable loop-termination condition



Pair Programming

1. [Find Minimum in Rotated Sorted Array](#)
2. [Koko Eating Bananas](#)

Practice Problems

1. [H-Index II - LeetCode](#)
2. [Search a 2D matrix](#)
3. [Heaters](#)
4. [The Meeting Place Cannot Be Changed](#)

Quote of the Day

“Believe you can and you're halfway there.”

~ ***Theodore Roosevelt***